

Course overview

Schooling for Diverse Populations in American Society

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[View the course syllabus](#)

[Visit the EDUC 219 Canvas site](#)

1 Course at a glance

Item	Details
Course	EDUC 219-01 — 3 credits
Term	Fall 2026
Meeting time	Monday and Wednesday, 5:10–6:20 p.m.
Location	MIN 124, Miner Building, School of Education
Instructor	Nathan Alexander, PhD
Email	nathan.alexander@howard.edu

Item	Details
In-person office hours	MIN 122H, Monday and Wednesday, 4:00–5:00 p.m.
Zoom appointments	Schedule an appointment

2 Course focus

EDUC 219 examines the philosophy, history, and sociology of American education, with particular attention to the ways diversity shapes the development and operation of the nation's education system. We will study social, political, and economic forces that have shaped American schools and educational opportunity, while considering how racial, cultural, linguistic, gender, income, and ability diversity affect teaching and learning.

Our work connects historical evidence, educational theory, and professional practice. Across the term, we will explore the relationship between schooling, democratic ideals, equal access, and social justice.

3 Course description

The course addresses the philosophy, history, and sociology of American education, particularly with regard to the role of diversity in the development and operation of the nation's education system. Particular attention will be paid to major social, political, and economic forces that have shaped and continue to shape American schools and educational practices.

Additionally, the course is designed to build among pre-service teachers a global awareness of how racial, cultural, linguistic, gender, income, and ability diversity affect educational opportunity. This course will enable candidates to:

- Discern the extent to which some forms of teaching and learning enhance democratic ideals while others do not.
- Begin to develop a professional identity that reflects the ideals of equal access and social justice.

4 Course objectives

Upon successfully completing the course, you will be able to:

- Explore social, political, and economic theories and research that distinguish multiculturalism, diversity, and social justice constructs that have shaped and continue to shape American schools and educational practices.
- Contrast the ideal of education and the reality of schooling in America for children from diverse racial, cultural, and linguistic backgrounds by exploring theories and research on stereotypes, prejudice, discrimination, the dynamics of power and privilege, and interlocking systems of oppression that affect teaching and learning.

- Explain the historical roots and trajectories of prejudice in the United States and integrate culturally relevant education into curriculum and/or practice.
- Develop learning experiences informed by the personal, social, cultural, and historical contexts of students and their communities.
- Demonstrate evidence of a professional identity that challenges the status quo and reflects agency regarding the education of African American and other diverse students.

5 Course learning sequence

The course moves from broad historical and philosophical inquiry toward collaborative case-based research and trial reenactment.

1. **Historical inquiry and timelines:** Students define criteria for historical significance, select historical bookend events, locate two primary-source artifacts, construct physical timelines, and contribute records to a shared digital timeline/database. The class database will identify whether an item is classified as a major event and whether it is directly related to education.
2. **Archival research and trial groups:** Students connect historical documents, events, and educational contexts to a selected *Plessy v. Ferguson* or *Brown v. Board of Education* trial group. Trial-group discussion posts and research will support the development of historical context, evidence, arguments, competing perspectives, and trial materials.
3. **Personal philosophy of education:** Each student will produce a final individual philosophy of education. This is not a philosophy of teaching. It should articulate the student's developing understanding of the purposes of education and the relationships among schools, democracy, access, diversity, power, and social justice.
4. **Supreme Court trial reenactments:** Working in groups, students will research, prepare, and present reenactments of *Plessy v. Ferguson* and *Brown v. Board of Education*, attending to historical context, legal claims, competing perspectives, and implications for educational opportunity and justice.

6 Required materials

Required book

Givens, J. R. (2021). *Fugitive Pedagogy: Carter G. Woodson and the Art of Black Teaching*. Harvard University Press. [Access through JSTOR](#).

Howard University provides access through the JSTOR link above. A physical copy may also be purchased from the University bookstore on Georgia Avenue.

Additional materials

- Additional readings and media are available through Canvas.
- The course reading list is available [here](#).
- Bring an in-class notebook, pencil or pen, and laptop.

7 Course work

Course component	Points
Archival research and personal philosophy of education	20
Quizzes	20
Midterm examination	30
Supreme Court trial reenactments	30
Total	100

See [Assignments and grading](#) for a course-work overview. Detailed assignment instructions, rubrics, submission procedures, and current deadlines are available on [Canvas](#).

8 Canvas

Canvas is the official course location for assignment submissions, readings, rubrics, discussion boards, announcements, and current course deadlines. Check [Canvas](#) and your Howard email regularly.

9 Expectations

This course asks you to engage seriously with historical evidence, educational theory, philosophical questions, and contemporary debates about schooling and educational opportunity. We will explore difficult issues concerning diversity, power, privilege, discrimination, access, democracy, and social justice. Be curious, thoughtful, prepared, and open to revising your understanding as we learn together.

- Communicate early and often.
- Attend class regularly and arrive on time.
- Participate thoughtfully and respectfully in class discussions and group work.
- Do not schedule other meetings during class time.
- Submit assignments by the deadlines listed on Canvas.
- If an issue affects your work, communicate with the instructor as early as possible.

10 Attendance and late work

Students are expected to attend class regularly and promptly. More than three absences will affect the final course grade. If you are absent, you remain responsible for all work missed.

Assignments are due by the deadlines identified on Canvas. Late work is deducted one-half letter grade for each day late. Students may submit one late assignment without penalty if it is turned in within two days of the due date and includes a note regarding the late work. All revised assignments must be submitted by the agreed-upon deadline.